

Pictures and the Decline of Literacy

Are illustrated books harming children's ability to read? The evidence may surprise you.

literacy · illiteracy · empirical evidence · illustrations · obtrusive · impoverished · redundant · comprehension · fluently · innate · detrimental · stimuli · primers · psycholinguistics

PART ONE · THE SCALE OF THE PROBLEM

- A** There is a great concern in Europe and North America about declining standards of literacy in schools. In Britain, the fact that 30 per cent of 16-year-olds have a reading age of 14 or less has helped to prompt massive educational changes. The development of literacy has far-reaching effects on general intellectual development, and thus anything which impedes the development of literacy is a serious matter for us all. So the hunt is on for the cause of the decline in literacy. The search so far has focused on socio-economic factors, or the effectiveness of 'traditional' versus 'modern' teaching techniques.
- B** The fruitless search for the cause of the increase in illiteracy is a tragic example of the saying 'They can't see the wood for the trees'. When teachers use picture books, they are simply continuing a long-established tradition that is accepted without question. And for the past two decades, illustrations in reading primers have become increasingly detailed and obtrusive, while language has become impoverished — sometimes to the point of extinction.

30%

of British 16-year-olds have a reading age of 14 or less

20+

years of increasingly obtrusive illustrations in reading primers

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empirical evidence supporting use of pictures in teaching reading

PART TWO · WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

- C** Amazingly, there is virtually no empirical evidence to support the use of illustrations in teaching reading. On the contrary, a great deal of empirical evidence shows that pictures interfere in a damaging way with all aspects of learning to read. Despite this, from North America to the Antipodes, the first books that many school children receive are totally without text.

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D A teacher's main concern is to help young beginner readers to develop not only the ability to recognise words, but the skills necessary to understand what these words mean. Even if a child is able to read aloud **fluently**, he or she may not be able to understand much of it: this is called **'barking at text'**. The teacher's task of improving **comprehension** is made harder by influences outside the classroom. But the adverse effects of such things as television, video games, or limited language experiences at home, can be offset by experiencing 'rich' language at school.

E Instead, it is not unusual for a book of 30 or more pages to have only one sentence full of repetitive phrases. The artwork is often marvellous, but the pictures make the language **redundant**, and the children have no need to imagine anything when they read such books. Looking at a picture actively prevents children younger than nine from creating a mental image, and can make it difficult for older children. In order to learn how to comprehend, they need to practise making their own meaning in response to text. They need to have their **innate** powers of imagination trained.

ARGUMENTS FOR PICTURE BOOKS

- Pictures are visually attractive and can draw children towards books.
- They may help with initial word recognition at the earliest stages.
- Colourful artwork can make reading feel like an enjoyable experience.
- Some children use images as context clues when stuck on a word.

ARGUMENTS AGAINST PICTURE BOOKS

- Pictures make language **redundant** — children lose the need to imagine.
- They prevent young children from developing their **innate** mental imagery.
- **Illustrations** can be **detrimental** and mislead children seeking word meaning.
- **Empirical evidence** consistently shows pictures slow and harm reading accuracy.

PART THREE · WIDER CONSEQUENCES

F As they grow older, many children turn aside from books without pictures, and it is a situation made more serious as our culture becomes more visual. It is hard to **wean** children off picture books when pictures have played a major part throughout their **formative** reading experiences, and when there is competition for their attention from so many other sources of entertainment. The least intelligent are most vulnerable, but tests show that even intelligent children are being affected. The response of educators has been to extend the use of pictures in books and to simplify the language, even at senior levels. The Universities of Oxford and Cambridge recently held joint conferences to discuss the noticeably rapid decline in **literacy** among their undergraduates.

G Pictures are also used to help motivate children to read because they are beautiful and eye-catching. But motivation to read should be provided by listening to stories well read, where children imagine in response to the story. Then, as they start to read, they have this experience to help them understand the language. If we present pictures to save children the trouble of developing these creative skills, then I think we are making a great mistake.

PART FOUR · THE RESEARCH

H Academic journals ranging from educational research, psychology, language learning, psycholinguistics, and so on cite experiments which demonstrate how detrimental pictures are for beginner readers. Here is a brief selection:

■ Dale Willows — Canadian Educationalist

Willows's results were clear and consistent: pictures affected both speed and accuracy, and the closer the pictures were to the words, the slower and more inaccurate the child's reading became. She claims that when children come to a word they already know, the pictures are unnecessary and distracting. If they do not know a word and look to the picture for a clue to its meaning, they may well be misled by aspects of the pictures which are not closely related to the meaning of the word they are trying to understand.

■ Jay Samuels — American Psychologist

Samuels found that poor readers given no pictures learnt significantly more words than those learning to read with books containing pictures. He examined other researchers who found that a word without a picture was superior to a word with a picture. When children were given words and pictures, those who seemed to ignore the pictures and pointed at the words learnt more words than children who pointed at the pictures — but they still learnt fewer words than children who had no illustrated stimuli at all.

■ TALKING POINTS

Do you think picture books harmed or helped your own reading development? Why?

The article argues that 'barking at text' — reading fluently without understanding — is a serious problem. Have you experienced this?

Should governments regulate how many pictures are allowed in school reading books? Who should decide?

The author argues that imagination must be 'trained'. Do you agree that it is a skill that needs practice?